

The Other Room

She had been writing the same novel for seven years.
Then she read something that changed what she
thought writing was.

CEFR Level B1

Book 9 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A flat in Edinburgh. A writing retreat in rural France. The novel that may or may not exist.

Genre: Literary Drama / Process

Characters

- Dara — 36. Novelist. Her first novel was well-received. Her second has been in progress for seven years.
- Patrick — her agent. Patient, commercial, genuinely invested.
- Claude — 74. A retired French novelist whom Dara meets on the retreat.
- The novel itself — the other room, always adjacent, never entered.

Dara had been writing the same novel for seven years.

This was not, she told people who asked, because she was slow or blocked. It was because the novel kept being wrong.

She had three complete drafts, of which the third was substantially better than the first but not yet right.

She had, over seven years, written approximately four hundred thousand words of a novel that was, in its current form, eighty thousand words long.

The novel was about a family. Three generations. A house in Ireland. What had been passed down and what had been withheld.

'What's the problem with it?' her agent Patrick had asked.

'I don't know yet,' she had said. 'That's the problem.'

current form mevcut biçimi passed down aktarılan "I don't know yet. That's the problem." Seven years and she still cannot name what is wrong.

It was in the Dordogne — a farmhouse that had been converted into a writing residency, with six studios and a shared kitchen.

She had resisted it for a year.

'I don't work well in groups,' she had said.

'You don't work at all at the moment,' Patrick had said, which was both unkind and accurate.

She went.

The farmhouse was in a valley between two ridges of limestone hills. The studios had large windows facing east.

She unpacked her laptop and the draft and sat at the desk.

The view was of a field and, beyond it, a line of poplars.

She thought: I could write here. Or I could not write here in a very picturesque setting.

limestone kireçtaşı picturesque pitoresk, güzel manzaralı unkind kırıcı She could write here. Or she could not write in a very picturesque setting. She is being honest.

writing non-fiction. One was Claude — a tall, thin Frenchman in his mid-seventies who had published, she learned from the residency notes, eleven novels over fifty years.

He did not ask what she was working on. She noticed this, because everyone else asked within the first hour.

On the third day, she asked him.

'I am writing a very short book,' he said. 'About twenty pages. I have been working on it for three years.'

'Three years for twenty pages?' 'Yes. It is a difficult twenty pages.'

'What's difficult about it?' 'I keep finding that I am writing around it instead of through it. Do you know that feeling?'

She knew that feeling extremely well.

published yayımladı extremely well son derece iyi writing around it etrafında yazmak through it içinden geçerek "Writing around it instead of through it." She knows this feeling. Seven years of it.

He was careful to answer accurately, which she appreciated, because many writers answered this question with either mystification or practicalities.

'I write until I stop,' he said. 'Then I ask why I stopped. Usually the stopping is information — it means I have arrived somewhere I haven't understood yet.'

'And then?' 'And then I stop working on the current passage and write about why I stopped. Not for the book. Just for myself. Trying to understand what I'm afraid of.'

'Afraid?' 'Yes. Almost all of the stopping is fear. Fear of what comes next — of the thing the book is actually about, which is usually not what you thought.'

She had three drafts of a novel about a family, three generations, a house in Ireland, inheritance and loss. She had always said, when asked what the novel was about, that it was about those things.

But Claude had said: what the book is actually about is usually not what you thought.

She sat at her desk that evening and did not open the draft. Instead she opened a new document and wrote the question at the top: What am I afraid this book is about?

She wrote for two hours.

She had not expected what came out.

house in Ireland.

But what it was actually about — what she had been circling for seven years without being able to approach directly — was her grandmother.

Her grandmother had died when Dara was fourteen. She had been, Dara had understood even then, the person in the family who held things together. After she died, things had come apart in ways that had taken years to name.

The novel had never explicitly featured the grandmother. She appeared briefly in the third generation sections — a memory, a reference.

Dara looked at what she had written.

She thought: I have been writing around her for seven years.

She told Claude the next morning, over coffee in the shared kitchen.

He listened without interrupting — which was, she had learned in three days, how he always listened.

'The person around whom everything organises,' he said.

'The person you can't look at directly.'

'Yes.'

'This is common,' he said. 'Not universal, but common. The book knows what it is about before the writer does. The writer arrives at the subject late.'

'Seven years,' she said.

'I've known writers who took longer. You were not avoiding — you were approaching. Slowly, but approaching.'

She thought about this. It was more generous than she felt she deserved.

The Other Room



Dara sits with the unfinished novel that has kept her waiting for years.

'How do you write through something you've been avoiding?' she asked.

'Directly,' he said. 'There is no other way.'

approaching yaklaşıyor slowly yavaşça generous cömert deserved hak etmiş "The book knows what it's about before the writer does." She arrived at her subject late. Now she must go directly.

She wrote the grandmother chapter on the fourth day of the residency.

She had not planned it. She had simply opened the draft, gone to the beginning of the third generation section, and started writing.

She wrote for six hours.

The chapter that came out was, she knew even as she was writing it, not quite right. But it was not wrong in the way the draft had been wrong.

It was wrong in the way that first approaches are wrong — it was too much, too present, too afraid of leaving anything out.

She had been leaving too much out. Now she was leaving nothing out.

'Both are mistakes,' Claude said, when she told him. 'But the second is easier to correct.'

In the second week, she rewrote the grandmother chapter four times.

Each version was better than the last and still not right.

She showed the fourth version to Claude.

He read it slowly, turning pages. He said nothing while he read.

When he finished, he said: 'The grandmother is here. But she is not yet fully present.'

'What does that mean?' 'You have told us what she did. You have not yet told us what it cost her.'

Dara looked at the pages.

She thought: I don't know what it cost her. That's why I've been avoiding it.

expected to.

But she had understood something she had not understood before: the chapter was not unwritten because she lacked the craft. It was unwritten because she lacked the knowledge.

She did not know, fully, what her grandmother had carried. She knew the shape of the absence. She did not know its contents.

She called her mother.

She said: 'I'm writing something about Nanna. I need to understand what her life was actually like — not the version I knew as a child.'

Her mother was quiet for a moment. 'That conversation is overdue,' she said.

They talked for four hours.

Dara learned things about her grandmother she had not known.

Her grandmother had married at nineteen. She had given up a scholarship to university — she had been accepted to study mathematics, which no one in the family had known. She had had four children and had raised them well and had, throughout, been the person who managed everything while appearing not to manage anything.

'Was she happy?' Dara asked.

'I don't know,' her mother said. 'I think she was — she used to say she was. But I think she also knew she had traded something. She just didn't think the trade was a mistake.'

'Did she say that?' 'Not exactly. But I understood it.'

Not in the sense that it had been a bad life — it had not been. But there was a life adjacent to it, which her grandmother had glimpsed and then turned away from, that needed to be acknowledged.

The Other Room



At the retreat, Claude questions what writing is really asking of her.

This was not something you could put into an essay about her grandmother. It was something you had to put into a novel, because a novel could hold the complexity of something being both right and costly.

She opened the draft.

She wrote the new version of the grandmother chapter in four days.

She read it back.

It was not perfect. But she could feel, for the first time in seven years, that she knew where the novel was going.

She called Patrick.

'I've broken through,' she said.

'What changed?' 'I found out what the novel was about.'

Patrick was quiet. 'You didn't know?' 'I knew what I thought it was about. I didn't know what it was actually about.'

'Is that different?' 'Yes. Significantly.'

She told him about the grandmother and the scholarship and the trade that had not been a mistake.

Patrick listened. He said: 'Is this in the book?'

'Yes. It's been in the book. I just hadn't written it properly yet.'

'How long until you're done?' 'I don't know. But I'm no longer writing around it.'

She told him about the scholarship and the mathematics.

He wrote back:

'The person around whom everything organises is often someone who made a choice that cost them something, and who never spoke about the cost. The family inherits the cost without inheriting the knowledge of where it came from. Your novel is about that inheritance.'

She read this several times.

She thought: yes. That is exactly what it is about.

She had not been able to say it in seven years. He said it in four sentences.

It was not the fastest she had written — her first novel had taken two years from first word to finished draft.

But it was, she thought, the most honest.

The grandmother was in the novel now — not as a presence in the third generation sections only, but woven through all three generations as the source of the thing that had been passed down and not named.

She read it back and thought: this is the book.

Not perfect. Not finished.

But this was the thing she had been trying to write.

She had been asked, in an interview after her first novel, what writing was.

She had given the answer she had prepared: a way of thinking, a form of attention, the thing that made her feel most fully herself.

These were all true.

But she had not known, then, the other true thing: that writing was also the process of approaching something you could not approach directly, circling it until you found the angle from which you could enter.

And that the circling was not wasted time.

It was the time you spent understanding what you were afraid of.

She had spent seven years circling her grandmother.

The circle had been necessary.

The reviews described it variously as 'generational,' 'quietly devastating,' and 'formally accomplished.'

One reviewer wrote: 'What distinguishes this novel from the author's first is its willingness to hold something irreducible at its centre — a loss that cannot be fully named but can be fully felt.'

Dara read this in a café in Edinburgh.

She thought about her grandmother. She thought about the scholarship. She thought about her mother's voice saying: I think she knew she had traded something.

The Other Room



In the other room at last, the work becomes possible again.

She thought: that reviewer understood what the book was about.

She thought: so did I, eventually.

His short book — twenty pages, three years in the writing — had been published in French.

He sent her a copy with a note: 'I am glad you found the other room. It was where the novel had been waiting.'

She looked up a translation of the title.

It was called: What the Stopping Means.

She thought about that for a long time.

She thought: yes. That is exactly it.

She wrote back: 'Your book arrived at the right moment. I will read it slowly.'

He replied: 'There is no other way to read it.'

She began thinking about the next novel six months after publication.

She had not been trying to. An idea had arrived — a sentence, a situation, a voice — and she had written it in her notebook.

She did not start writing immediately.

She had learned, from the seven years, that the first version of what you think you're writing is not usually what you are actually writing.

She gave the idea six months in the notebook before she began.

In those six months, she let it tell her what it was.

She wrote around it, carefully, until she found the angle. Then she began.

She had described the novel, in the seven years she was writing it, as being in the other room.

Not impossible to reach. Adjacent. Present. But not yet entered.

The other room was where the real thing was.

The work was getting to the door.

She understood now that the door had always been there — she had just been, for seven years, on the wrong side of it.

The novel she was writing next was in another other room. She was not afraid of this.

She had been to one other room already.

She knew the way in.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

1. blocked	yaratıcı tıkanıklık
2. substantially	önemli ölçüde
3. withheld	saklanan, saklanmış
4. approximately	yaklaşık olarak
5. residency	ikamet, rezidans
6. converted	dönüştürülmüş
7. Dordogne	Fransa'da bölge
8. non-fiction	kurgu dışı eserler
9. residency notes	rezidans notları
10. mystification	gizemleştirme
11. practicalities	pratik bilgiler
12. passage	bölüm, pasaj
13. accurately	doğru olarak
14. afraid of	... dan korkmak
15. actually about	aslında hakkında olan
16. inheritance	miras
17. instead	yerine
18. came out	ortaya çıktı
19. open the draft	taslağı açmak
20. new document	yeni belge
21. what came out	ortaya çıkan şey
22. circling	etrafında dolaşmak
23. approach directly	doğrudan yaklaşmak
24. held things together	her şeyi bir arada tuttu
25. explicitly featured	açıkça yer aldı
26. come apart	dağılmak
27. reference	atıf, referans
28. organises around	etrafında organize olur
29. universal	evrensel
30. first approaches	ilk yaklaşımlar
31. leaving out	dışarıda bırakmak
32. simply	sadece
33. too present	fazla mevcut
34. correct	düzeltilmek
35. went to	gitti
36. fully present	tam olarak mevcut
37. told us what it cost her	ne bedel ödediğini anlattı
38. turning pages	sayfaları çevirdi

39. still not right	hâlâ doğru değil
40. rewrote	yeniden yazdı
41. version	sürüm
42. lacked the craft	zanaatından yoksundu
43. lacked the knowledge	bilgiden yoksundu
44. contents	içerik
45. overdue	gecikmiş
46. shape of the absence	yokluğun şekli
47. fully	tam olarak
48. scholarship	burs
49. mathematics	matematik
50. accepted to	... a kabul edilmiş
51. managed everything	her şeyi yönetti
52. trade	takas, değiş tokuş
53. throughout	boyunca
54. adjacent	bitişik
55. glimpsed	bir anlığına gördü
56. acknowledged	kabul edilmek
57. costly	bedelli, maliyetli
58. complexity	karmaşıklık
59. turned away from	... den yüz çevirdi
60. broken through	aşıldı, geçildi
61. significantly	önemli ölçüde
62. done	bitti
63. properly	düzgünce
64. writing around it	etrafında yazmak
65. changed	değişti
66. inherits the cost	maliyeti miras alır
67. cost them something	bir bedel ödedi
68. without inheriting the knowledge	bilgiyi miras almadan
69. several times	birkaç kez
70. exactly	tam olarak
71. four sentences	dört cümle
72. woven through	içine dokunmuş
73. passed down	aktarılan
74. source	kaynak
75. honest	dürüst
76. not named	adlandırılmamış

77. the thing she had been trying to write	yazmaya çalıştığı şey
78. form of attention	dikkat biçimi
79. angle	açı, bakış açısı
80. wasted time	boşa harcanan zaman
81. enter	girmek
82. approaching	yaklaşmak
83. generational	kuşaklar arası
84. devastating	yıkıcı
85. formally accomplished	biçimsel açıdan başarılı
86. irreducible	indirgenemez
87. distinguishes	ayırt eder
88. willingness	isteklilik
89. short book	kısa kitap
90. published in French	Fransızca yayımlandı
91. looked up a translation	çevirisini aradı
92. What the Stopping Means	Durmanın Anlamı
93. arrived at the right moment	doğru anda geldi
94. slowly	yavaşça
95. an idea had arrived	bir fikir geldi
96. gave the idea time	fikre zaman verdi
97. let it tell her	ona anlatmasına izin verdi
98. the angle	açı, giriş noktası
99. six months in the notebook	defterde altı ay
100. carefully	dikkatle
101. present	mevcut
102. entered	girilmiş
103. the way in	içeri girme yolu
104. already	zaten
105. not afraid	korkmayan

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

1. blocked

A. yaratıcı tıkanıklık

2. residency

B. rezidans, ikamet

3. withheld

C. saklanmış

4. circling

D. etrafında dolaşmak

5. irreducible

E. indirgenemez

6. woven through

F. içine dokunmuş

7. generational

G. kuşaklar arası

8. angle

H. açı, giriş noktası

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

fear — grandmother — seven — around — cost — directly

1. Dara had been writing the same novel for

_____ **years.**

2. Claude said that almost all of the stopping in writing is

_____.

3. She had been writing _____ her grandmother for

seven years without being able to approach her directly.

4. She realised the novel was actually about her _____
— the person she had been circling.
5. Her mother said her grandmother knew she had traded
something — but didn't think the _____ was a mistake.
6. Claude told her: you have to write through it _____.
There is no other way.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Dara has written and published two novels before this story begins. ____

2. Patrick is Dara's editor at a publishing house. ____

3. Claude has published eleven novels. ____

4. Dara finishes the grandmother chapter during the residency. ____
5. Dara's grandmother had been accepted to study literature at university. ____
6. Claude's short book is called 'What the Stopping Means.'

Short Answer Questions

7. Why has Dara been unable to finish the novel despite having written three drafts?
8. What does Claude mean by 'writing around it instead of through it'?
9. What does Dara discover about the real subject of her novel?
10. What does Claude say about the grandmother character after reading the fourth version?
11. What does Dara learn from the conversation with her mother?
12. How does Claude summarise what the novel is about in his letter?
13. What does the reviewer say that shows they understood the novel?
14. How does Dara approach the next novel differently from how she approached this one?
15. What does 'the other room' represent in the story?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-A 2-B 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. seven 2. fear 3. around 4. grandmother 5. cost 6. directly

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. F 5. F 6. T

7. She does not know what is wrong — she has the craft but lacks the knowledge of what the novel is actually about.

8. Approaching the real subject of the work indirectly, through surrounding material, instead of entering it directly.

9. The novel is about her grandmother — the person who held the family together and around whom everything organises.

10. He says the grandmother is present but not fully present — she has told the reader what the grandmother did, but not what it cost her.

11. Her grandmother gave up a mathematics scholarship at nineteen, married, and raised four children — she had traded something, but didn't think it was a mistake.

12. The family inherits the cost of a choice without inheriting the knowledge of where it came from. The novel is about that inheritance.

13. The reviewer says the novel holds something irreducible at its centre — a loss that cannot be fully named but can be fully felt.

14. She gives the idea six months in a notebook before beginning, letting it tell her what it actually is before she starts writing.

15. The real subject of the work — the thing you are circling and cannot yet approach directly, which is adjacent to what you think you are writing, and which is where the real work waits.